

ASSERTION

STUDENT ACTIVITIES

Don't Be A Disser (michelleborba.com)

Skill Focus: recognizing bullying, put downs, standing up for self

Grade Level: K - 6

Description: Have the class look for ways people treat each other in TV shows. Do they put each other down and try to make each other feel stupid? Or are they kind and helpful toward each other? In what types of shows are they kind and helpful? The children could also look for role models of helping or put-down behavior in books or stories.

Know Your Helpers (goodcharacter.com)

Skill Focus: identifying helpers, getting/asking for help

Grade Level: K - 6

Description: Have the class work in small groups to brainstorm different kinds of help kids can get from others. Each group focuses on a particular group of helpers such as teachers, friends, siblings, or parents. Making a classroom bulletin board or posters showing different kinds of help and potential helpers could expand this activity.

Helping Buddies (goodcharacter.com)

Skill Focus: getting/asking for help, attempting work before asking staff

Grade Level: 4 - 6

Description: Divide the class into pairs of "helping buddies." Each buddy has two tasks: (1) decide on some knowledge or skill he or she would like to improve and (2) work with his or her buddy to improve the knowledge or skill-- or get the necessary help. The buddies meet regularly for a week or two and then report to the class on how they helped each other improve.

Puppet Skit or Role Play: Dealing with a Bully (teachablemoment.org)

Skill Focus: standing up for self

Grade Level: K - 3

Description: Write the word "bully" on the board. What's a bully? Elicit that a bully is a person who threatens other people (usually smaller than himself), sometimes hurting them and forcing them to do things they don't want to do.

Explain that the puppets are now going to act out a situation with a bully, and then the class is going to figure out how to deal with situation. Sometimes the best way to come up with a good idea is for a whole group to think about the problem and brainstorm solutions. As they say, two (or more) heads are better than one.

The puppet skit might go something like this:

Juan and Tyrone, first graders, are talking in a corner of the school playground about a fifth-grader named Robert.

Juan: I hate Robert!

Tyrone: Yes, he's really mean.

Juan: I just had to give him my candy. He said he'd beat me up after school if I didn't.

Tyrone: I know. Yesterday he told me he'd get me on the way home if I didn't give him my cookies from lunch. He thinks he's big and bad because he's in fifth grade.

Juan: Yes, and I don't like the way he bosses us around. Remember last week when we were in line for the drinking fountain and he cut right in front of us and pushed us out of the way?

Freeze the action at this point. What's going on here? After the students describe the situation, suggest that they brainstorm ways Juan and Tyrone could deal with the problem of Robert, the bully.

Explain the rules of brainstorming: no comments on other people's ideas, the ideas don't have to be "realistic," go for as many ideas as possible in a short amount of time.

Discuss: Have you ever had an experience with a bully? What do you think of the ideas the class came up with? Could you see using any of them to deal with a real-life bully?

Quick Thinking: Standing Up Against Unfairness (role play) (teachablemoment.org)

Skill Focus: standing up for self

Grade Level: K - 6

Description: Describe a problematic situation (like the ones below) to the class. Give the students, working in pairs, a minute or two to come up with an idea for addressing it the situation. Another option is work as a whole class. When the time is up, the pairs share their idea with the group. The aim is to generate lots of ideas and get people thinking, not necessarily to come up with the "best" approach.

Explain that the students will generate ideas for stopping people from treating each other unfairly. Here are some possible situations that you might suggest for "quick thinking":

- A group of boys is playing kickball. A girl asks to play and is told, "No! Girls aren't any good at basketball!"
- A boy is being teased because his hair is long. Other kids are teasing him saying, "He looks like a girl."
- Two girls are close friends and the other kids start to tease them, saying, "You're gay."
- A boy, who likes to read during recess and participates a lot in class, is teased by others who say, "He's a nerd!"
- A new girl, who just emigrated from another country, brings lunch from home that is different from everyone else's lunch. The other kids tease her saying, "Ick! She eats disgusting food!"

Afterwards, evaluate the workshop as a class. Ask students: What's one thing you learned in today's workshop? It's not easy to stop people when they're treating others unfairly. Can you see yourself using some of the ideas you came up with in "Quick Thinking"?

I-Messages and the Assertiveness Line (teachablemoment.org)

(By Amy Martin)

Skill Focus: standing up for self

Grade Level: K - 6

Description: Begin by writing "I-message" on the board. Explain that today the students will learn what an I-message is and how to construct one.

An I-message is a way to be strong, or assertive, without being mean when you are angry or upset or disappointed with something another person has done. The formula for an I-message is as follows:

<u>I feel</u>	<u>(say your feeling)</u>
<u>when you</u>	<u>(describe the action)</u>
<u>because</u>	<u>(say why the action connects to</u>
<u>your feeling)</u>	

The "I-message" is different from a "You-message." In a "You-message," you attack the other person, make judgments about him or her, and sometimes even call the person names.

For example, say the class is picking partners for an activity. You pick John, who wants to work with his best friend instead of with you. He lets you know by pouting and mumbling, "aaw!" You say, "You want to work with him? Fine! You're too stupid to work with me, anyway!"

Ask the class: How do you think John might feel about being called stupid? Will he be more or less likely to choose you as a partner in the future?

In this situation, what would an "I-message" be? Elicit possible "I-messages" from the students. (For example: "I feel disappointed when you always want to work with your best friend because I never get to spend time with you.")

I-Messages can also be used to express positive feelings. (For example, "I'm excited that you are coming because we always have so much fun on your visits.") Encourage your students to share other examples.

Discussion: Can you see using an I-message the next time you feel upset and think of calling somebody a name? Why? Why not?

Role Play: Once you have introduced the structure of an I-message, you can have children practice it before challenging times of the day, such as lunch, recess or gym.

As you have the class line up for leaving the room, practice using I-messages. Create two lines with the children facing each other. Explain that all the children in one line will be Child A and all the children in the other line will be Child B. Ask them to pretend that Child A and Child B were playing at recess. Child A runs off without saying anything to Child B and begins to play with someone else. Then say, "Does everybody understand the situation? Okay. When I say 'Go,' everybody who is pretending to be Child B will use an I-message to say to Child A. When I say 'Freeze,' stop immediately and get quiet. Say, "Go!" Let the action run for a minute or so. Then stop the action. Ask, what happened in your pairs? How did Child B respond to Child A? After hearing from several pairs, remind them that the I-message is a tool that they can use to let others know how they are feeling without being mean.

Role Play I - Messages (teachablemoment.org)

Skill Focus: standing up for self

Grade Level: K - 6

Once your students become skillful with using I-Messages, you might explore with them what it means to "be strong," "be mean," or "give in." After briefly discussing what they know of these words, share with them these definitions:

Strong = being nice and respecting the other person while standing up firmly for yourself.

Mean = doing something to hurt another person (their body or their feelings) or using force or threats to make somebody do something they don't want to do.

Giving in = going along with what someone wants you to do even though you'd rather do something else.

Elicit examples of each of the behaviors for the children. You may also use the words assertive, aggressive, and submissive depending on age-appropriateness. Practice the assertiveness line with other situations that the students encounter daily. Encourage them to discover ways of being strong without being mean.

Continue the routine with situations that your class is currently struggling with. Here are some examples of times when it might be helpful to be "strong" or assertive:

- A friend borrows your game and returns it to you with pieces missing.
- You share something with a friend on the condition that the friend not tell anyone else. Soon everyone in your class knows about it.
- You feel your parents blame you unfairly for things your brother does.

"Go Fly a K.I.T.E." (developed by Ron Huxley 2008)

Skill Focus: standing up for yourself,

Grade Level: 4 - 6

Description: No, this isn't being rude. It is being assertive! Each letter of the acronym K.I.T.E.

explains a different skill to teach children how to be more assertive.

K = Know what you want.

Before you can be assertive, you have to be clear on what you want to gain. Help the student state specifically what he or she wants from another person or situation. Does he want a bully to treat him respectfully? Does she want to make friends more easily? Make this statement concrete and positive. Don't state: "I don't want you to pick on me anymore." Phrase it positively: "I would like you to play nice with me when we are together."

I = Use I messages Vs. You messages

"I" messages start with the word "I." "You" messages start with the word "You." After you know what you want, you have to ask for what you want. "I" message will increase the chances of getting what you want.

T = Tell others what you want firmly and repeatedly.

Using these steps will increase your chances, and usually have good results, but never guarantee you will get what you want. Therefore, you may have to be very firm and repeatedly express your wants and needs. Most bullies continue to be bullies because they know you will back down. If students are firm and repeat their wants and needs, they increase their chances even more.

E = Expect change/Evaluate effectiveness.

Most efforts at being assertive fail because we don't really believe they will work in the first place. Assertiveness should be considered an "experiment" in getting what you want. If one approach doesn't work, try another. Evaluate how effective your assertive behaviors are with others. Talk with students about what could be done differently and try that next time. This teaches problem solving skills, which are an important element in social skill development.

A Role Play on Choices (teachablemoment.org)

Skill Focus: standing up for yourself

Grade Level: 4 - 6

Description: The role play below picks up on the theme of being different as well as on the challenge of standing up to peer pressure. If it doesn't seem appropriate for your class, please create another tailored to your class's needs.

Here's the situation. Jennie is different from the other kids in the class in several ways: she always wears dresses (rather than the jeans and t-shirts the other kids wear); the dresses often seem out of style and a bit big on her; she's shy; and whether in the classroom, the lunchroom or the school yard, she always carries a notebook around with her for her favorite activity, writing.

Victoria is the most popular girl in the class, a leader. She decides she wants to have some fun by getting several other girls to join her in a plan to get Jennie's notebook away from her and hide it.

Victoria approaches Latoya, one of several girls in the class who like to hang out with her, and tells her of the plan. "The only time she isn't holding that stupid notebook is when she works at the computer," says Victoria. "Watch her closely and when you get your chance, take the notebook and give it to me. I'll find a good place for it."

Latoya admires Victoria and enjoys being her friend. Being friends with Victoria gives her status in the class. However, she doesn't like this idea. First, she's pretty sure that if she takes part in the scheme, she'll get in trouble. But she also has nothing against Jennie. Sure, she's a little strange, but Jennie has always been nice to her; in fact, Jennie gave her half of her sandwich when she'd forgotten her lunch one day.

So Latoya doesn't want to take part in Victoria's plan. In fact, she doesn't want Victoria to do anything to hurt Jennie. But it's also important for her to remain Victoria's friend. And she doesn't want the other kids in the class to look down on her, as they do Jennie.

Ask for three volunteers: one to play Victoria, one to play Latoya, and one to be the narrator (this might be a good role for staff, who will fill in necessary background). Brief your actors on their roles.

Make nametags for them with the names they will have in the role-play. Use the names suggested above only if they are the names of no children in your class.

A good ritual for beginning role-plays is to lead the class saying in unison, "Lights, camera, action!"
Now, run the skit.

- Freeze the action while Victoria is still trying to convince Latoya to help her carry out her plan.
- Ask, what is happening? Encourage the students to describe what is going on as objectively as possible. Then ask, how do you think the characters are feeling?
- Ask, what are Latoya's choices? What are the different ways she might deal with the situation?
- Elicit the student's ideas and write them on the board. Push them to come up with a wide range of possibilities.
- Discuss: What do you think is the right thing for Latoya to do in this situation? Why? Do you think that will be easy or hard for her? What would you do? Why?

Latoya, Victoria and Jennie - a reprise (teachablemoment.org)

Skill Focus: standing up for yourself, getting adult help

Grade Level: 4 - 6

Description: This lesson is an extension activity of the lesson above, **A Role Play on Choices**. Refer to the role-play with Victoria and Latoya. Ask the children to recall the situation. Say that one way to make a good choice is to think ahead about what is likely to happen as a result of your choice.

Select student volunteers to replay the skit as before, except this time they will act out one of the ideas the class proposed as choices for Latoya. Confer with the student playing Latoya and ask her to decide which course of action she'll have Latoya follow. It can be any of the choices; it doesn't have to be the one the student thinks is best.

Run the skit: "Lights, camera, action!"

Freeze the action after the two characters have had some dialogue back and forth. Ask the students to describe what has happened in the role-play. What choice did the character Latoya make? How has Victoria responded? What do they think will happen next?

Have student actors act out several of Latoya's choices and discuss as above. The aim is not to arrive at a definitive answer about what will happen in any given situation, but to show the children that it's possible -- and important -- to anticipate consequences.

Additional Role Play Scenarios (teachablemoment.org)

- You want to be alone, but a friend wants to be with you. What do you do?
- A classmate teases you or calls you a name. How do you respond?
- You're walking along a busy city street with your mom and decide you want an ice cream cone. You know your mom won't be enthusiastic about the idea. How do you ask?
- Your family is having a conversation around the dinner table, and you have an opinion you'd like to state, but everyone is talking so fast. How do you get people to listen to what you have to say?
- An older kid says you have to give him the cake from your lunch or he'll beat you up.
- Two close friends ask you to join them in stealing money from another kid's backpack.
- Your younger brother keeps bothering you when you're trying to do your homework.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS AND/OR WRITING ASSIGNMENTS

- Have you ever felt embarrassed because you didn't know something or couldn't do something? How did it feel? What did you do about it?
- Why can it be hard to admit you don't know something? What could happen?
- Have you seen kids try to make others feel stupid? What makes them do that?
- Think about a time when you needed help because you didn't know how to do something. Who did you turn to? How did you feel asking for help?
- If you're having trouble with schoolwork, what can you do about it? What can happen if you don't do anything?
- If you need help but don't ask for it, how can that lead to more problems?
- What can you say or do when someone you know needs help?
- What would you do if a friend of yours gave you an expensive present, but you found out it was stolen? How do you feel when someone tells you a lie?
- Do you think that lying can ruin a friendship? Explain. Has that ever happened to you?
- If you tell just one lie, does that make you a liar? How many lies do you get to tell before you are a liar?
- Would you trust somebody who lies? Who cheats? Who steals? Why, or why not?
- How do you know if you can trust someone?

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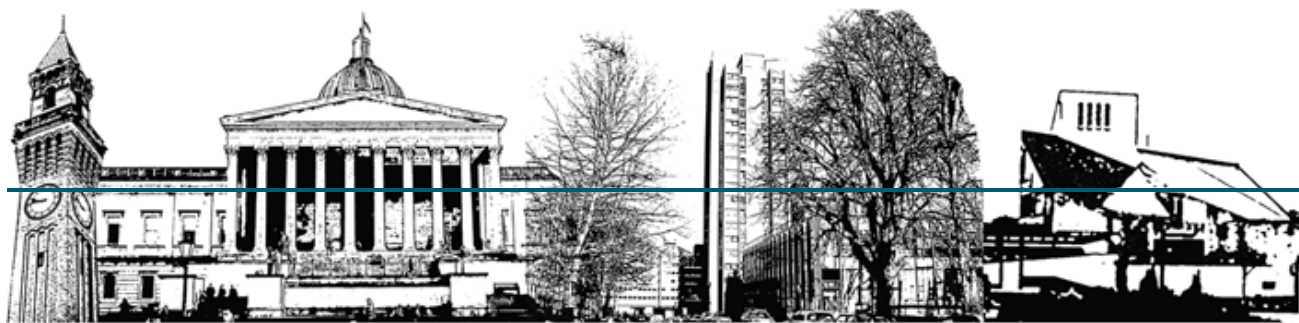
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‘FILLING IN THE GAPS’: A MICRO-SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS OF AUTISM

October 15, 2013

By Damian E M Milton

Abstract:

When reviewing research related to autism, it is clear that it is dominated by biological and psychological concerns, with autism being defined as a developmental deviance, dysfunction, and deficit. Much of this research assumes a functionalist philosophy regarding deviations from statistical norms as pathological and in need of remediation. This research feeds into a hegemonic view of what constitutes ‘normalcy’, with critical social explanations being lost under the sheer mass of research from this viewpoint. Despite the ascendancy of this functionalist philosophy, there is a growing concern regarding listening to ‘autistic voices’ from a phenomenological perspective (Biklen, 2005) and with regards to the wider social construction of autism (Nadesan, 2005; Timini et al. 2011). However, the study of autism on a micro-sociological level has been given precious little attention. This paper utilises the theories of Garfinkel (1967) and Goffman (1955, 1959, 1963, 1974) in particular, in order to question current ways of perceiving autism, highlighting issues concerning social interactions involving autistic people, and the stigma of autism, as well as deconstructing the ‘myth’ of a ‘lack of empathy’ (Baron-Cohen, 2008; 2011).

‘Filling in the Gaps’: A Micro-Sociological Analysis of Autism

By Damian E M Milton

introduction

A currently popular model for researching health issues is the ‘biopsychosocial’ (BPS) model of health (Engel, 1977). This model attempts to move beyond the traditional biomedical model of health that framed health and illness in terms of a biological deviation from ‘normal’ functioning, due to pathogens, developmental abnormalities, or injury. The BPS model looks beyond this reductionist framework to include psychological and social factors that affect health, with each factor interacting and impacting on each other. The model has been criticised however, for a lack of theoretical integration between these factors, and for simply stating an obvious fact (Pilgrim, 2002). Pilgrim (2002) also states that the BPS model has not been fully realised and that the biomedical model is still dominant.

When reviewing research related to autism, it is clear that it is dominated by biological and psychological concerns, with autism being defined as a developmental deviance, dysfunction, and deficit. Much of this research assumes a functionalist philosophy regarding deviations from statistical norms as pathological, and in need of remediation. This philosophy is taken for granted when looking at the social context of autism, in which autistic people are perceived to be socially abnormal and dysfunctional, with much policy related research taking an economic perspective of the ‘cost of autism’ (Knapp et al. 2009). This research feeds into a hegemonic view of what constitutes ‘normalcy’, with critical social explanations being lost under the sheer mass of research from this viewpoint.

“Although there is a biological aspect to this condition named autism, the social factors involved in its identification, representation, interpretation, remediation, and performance are the most important factors in the determination of what it means to be autistic, for individuals, for families and for society.” (Nadesan, 2005, p. 2).

In the ‘Ecological Systems Theory’ developed by the psychologist Urie Brofenbrenner (1979), rather than examining the inner environment of the child, psychological development is seen within a context of wider social systems working at four levels: the microsystem (the immediate social environments that people inhabit), the mesosystem (where two microsystems interact), the exosystem (a broader social context which indirectly influences development), and the macrosystem (the wider social context). This theory forms a framework within which one can examine various levels of social context in the study of autism. Within the field of autism, there is a growing concern regarding listening to ‘autistic voices’ from a phenomenological perspective (Biklen, 2005) and with regard to the wider social construction of autism (Nadesan, 2005; Timini et al. 2011). However, the study of autism on a micro-sociological level has been given precious little attention. This paper utilises the theories of Garfinkel (1967) and Goffman (1955, 1959, 1963, 1974) in particular, in order to question current ways of perceiving autism, highlighting issues concerning social interactions involving autistic people, and the stigma of autism, as well as deconstructing the ‘myth’ of a ‘lack of empathy’ (Baron-Cohen, 2008; 2011).

Ethnomethodology and Autism

The ethnomethodological perspective was first formalised by Garfinkel (1967), as a development from phenomenological theory. The term ‘Ethno’ referring to the stock of commonsense knowledge available

to a member of a society (e.g. the rules of a game of noughts and crosses), and ‘Methodology’ in this instance referring to the methods or strategies that people employ in different settings to make their

intended meanings understandable (e.g. turn-taking in conversations). An ethnomethodologist suspends or abandons the belief that an actual social order exists, but rather, suggests that social reality is accomplished and continually constructed by 'skilled social actors'.

Through his 'breaching' experiments, Garfinkel (1967) deliberately violated social reality, in order to shed light on the methods used by people to construct and maintain social reality. Garfinkel (1967) argued that social reality was fragile in nature, and when the 'natural attitude' (the belief that everything is how one thinks it is and others perceive things in much the same way) is 'breached' people are put under a state of stress and do everything in their power to repair the breach. Reactions to breaching can be extreme, yet this also shows the importance people place on maintaining order in their views of the social world.

Rather than lacking a 'theory of mind', it is argued here that due to differences in the way autistic people process information, they are not socialised into the same shared 'ethno' as 'neurotypical' people, and thus 'breaches' in understanding happen all the time, leaving both in a state of confusion. The difference is that the neurotypical person can repair the breach, by the reassuring belief that approximately 99 out of 100 people still think and act like they do, and remind themselves that they are the 'normal' ones. For McGeer (2004) the 'theory of mind' deficit model of autism is a one-sided asymmetrical view of two people failing to understand one another, with the personal accounts of those diagnosed showing that the supposed lack of subjective awareness of self and others is simply untrue.

The Myth of Empathy

Ethnomethodologists such as Garfinkel (1967) and Cicourel (1974) suggest that interactions between individuals involve assumptions of 'normalcy', such as the assumption that others will behave in expected ways, and that when ambiguous meanings are found, they will either be deemed irrelevant to the interaction, or will be immanently explained. Such 'interpretive procedures' involve an inductive logical process, without which an individual would be uncertain of the meaning of the interaction, what was to happen next, and perceiving how others may be experiencing the interaction. According to Durig (1993), the impairments and abilities associated with autism can be seen with regard to the use of deductive and abductive reasoning, rather than inductive logic. For Durig (1993), deductive intellectual activities involve 'if then' rules, especially those with a guaranteed outcome, such as numerical calculation, memorising information, or collecting objects, whilst abductive activities involve creativity and imagination. Durig's (1993) classification of autism as a preference/reliance on deductive logic (in particular) as opposed to inductive inference, gives an alternative way to conceptualise Baron-Cohen's (2008) 'empathising-systemising' theory. Rather than a lack of 'theory of mind' or ability to empathise, Durig (1993) suggests that an apparent inability in this area comes from a different way of processing information, which does bear a resemblance to Baron-Cohen's (2008) conceptualisation of autistic strengths coming from an ability for 'splitting' and 'systemising', yet does not involve the need to use a concept of empathy. This formulation would also suggest that rather than being a 'core deficit', the appearance of a lack of 'theory of mind' would be a potential consequence of an individual processing interactions with others using deductive, rather than inductive logic.

According to Baron-Cohen (2011), a lack of intent to cause harm can co-exist with 'zero empathy', and suggests that this is the pattern found with autistic people, suggesting that they are 'zero positive', rather than 'zero negative' (as he suggests is the case with other neurological labels of pathology). This line of thinking however implies that a lack of empathy does not in and of itself lead to criminality or cruelty to others, but the intent to cause harm to others. Thus, if one were able to banish a lack of empathy, one would not banish cruelty. The formulation of 'zero negative' (and thus 'zero positive') does not make sense however, as the intent to cause harm would require some sense of understanding regarding the existence of others outside of oneself, as well as notions of cause and effect regarding one's actions on others. In other words, cruelty requires 'cognitive empathy' which is said to be lacking in the case of 'zero negative' individuals.

The amount of apparent 'empathy' expressed by an individual (autistic or not) will vary depending on who they are interacting with, and the wider social context, on both their ability to understand the attention of others, and in emotional reactions to this information. It is argued here that 'empathy' is a convenient illusion, and the phenomenon that people speak of when referring to it has more to do with language and a sense of 'shared' cultural meanings/symbols (or their 'ethno'). It can be argued that neuro-typical people have no better understanding of how autistics think, than vice versa (McGeer, 2004). The philosopher Thomas Nagel (1981) wrote about the impossibility of understanding what it may be like to be a bat, yet this could be expanded to all other creatures, including humans. By looking at the breaching experiments of Garfinkel (1967), one can see the fragile nature of the social reality that people inhabit. Garfinkel argued that people have a tendency to 'fill in the gaps' in their perception in order to gain what they think is a full or whole picture. Due to differences in the way autistic people process information (whether it be monotropism, a weak drive toward central coherence, a lack of mirror-neurons, or a lack of long-range connectivity in the brain), this 'filling of gaps' tends not to occur (at least to the same extent). Autistic people have a tendency to be more literal, and work upon what is tangible and present, thus conclusions are reached through available information (without 'filling in the gaps'). It is also interesting to note that these issues may well have been partly recognised in the work of Hans Asperger:

"Asperger may have believed that his patients lacked the natural attitude that constitutes the socially-shared lifeworld, as understood phenomenologically." (Nadesan, 2005, pp. 76).

It has been suggested that a 'theory of mind' and empathy are essential to that which makes humans what they are. Thus, the characterisation of autistic people lacking such abilities suggests that they are somewhat less than fully human (Lawson, 2010), and when also linked to criminality and cruelty to others, brings back notions of the 'atavistic criminal'. It is argued here, that depicting autistic people as 'lacking empathy', is an inaccurate and potentially highly dangerous narrative to pursue.

'Us' and 'Them'

People have a tendency to align themselves to others within their 'in-group' and increase this bond through the denigration of 'out-groups' (Tajfel and Turner, 1979). Within interactions with others of an in-group, it can be easily shown that people have little compassion (or 'affective empathy') for 'outsiders'. Tajfel and Turner (1979) utilising 'minimal group experiments' found that this denigration also occurred, even when distinctions between groups were arbitrary.

According to the 'Social Identity Theory' of Tajfel and Turner (1979), individuals increase their self-image by identifying positively with a group to which they belong, but also by discriminating against the 'out-group'. Tajfel and Turner (1979) suggested that stereotyping others was a normal cognitive process, in which there is a tendency to group phenomena together. In doing so, the differences between groups are exaggerated, along with similarities to those within the 'in-group', through a process of categorisation, identification, and comparison.

Link and Phelan (2001) suggest that stigma occurs through four social processes. Firstly, by human difference being labelled, secondly by dominant cultural ideology linking labelled individuals to undesirable characteristics, or negative stereotypes, thirdly a dislocation between groups establishes a distinction between 'us' and 'them', and lastly labelled individuals experience discrimination and a loss of status. In this conceptualisation, stigma is contingent upon differentials of social power.

Stigma and Autism

Durkheim (1895) was the first sociologist to consider yourself to be stigma as a social phenomena:

"Imagine a society of saints, a perfect cloister of exemplary individuals. Crimes or deviance, properly so-called, will there be unknown; but faults, which appear venial to the layman, will there create the same scandal that the ordinary offense does in ordinary consciousnesses. If then, this society has the power to

judge and punish, it will define these acts as criminal (or deviant) and will treat them as such.” (Durkheim, 1895).

In this early functionalist formulation of stigma and deviance, both are viewed as inevitable within human societies, and indeed functional for society in terms of maintaining a moral code of values, supporting the social norms of a society and the stability of society as a whole. Although this view has been criticised from a number of perspectives, it is interesting to note that Durkheim also argued that another function of deviance in society was to challenge society and open up possibilities for social change. For Durkheim, a society with an overly strict moral code of behaviour would be just as dysfunctional as an anomie society with a lack of such a ‘consensus’, an idea sadly lacking in much subsequent functionalist or New Right sociological theory (Parsons, 1951; Murray, 1990).

- In the field of autism, such a functionalist view of society and an honest person? Why? individual’s place within it, are often taken for granted, depicting autistic people as a financial burden in need of correction and ‘normalisation’. As Timini et al. (2011) argue, being viewed as ‘normal’ has become progressively harder to achieve:
- What does trustworthiness mean to you? What is a trustworthy person?
- Do you consider yourself a trustworthy person? In what way are you a trustworthy person?

“The desire to control, amend or even extinguish human behaviours that depart from an increasingly narrow stereotype of normality has bedevilled the history of psychiatry.” (Timini et al., 2011, p. 8).

Lawson (2008) suggests that the discipline of psychology has largely conditioned social concepts of what it is to be ‘normal’, yet also highlights the role of media and big business in maintaining these concepts. Lawson (2008) calls for an expansion of what is considered ‘normal’, and suggests that society is intolerant and non-inclusive of difference, preventing the healthy development of a wide population of people. This can be seen as an attempt to reduce the social stigma attached to autism and difference more generally, yet without the abolishment of the label, as is suggested by Timini et al. (2011). Indeed, it is argued here that such a move would not extinguish discrimination against those currently deemed autistic. This can be shown by a recent study into autistic epidemiology in adults in England (Traolach et al., 2011), which found that of those exhibiting autism, none were formally diagnosed. Yet in comparison to non-autistics, were likely to have a lower level of education and employment, and to be more likely to be living in government housing.

According to Cottrell (1942, 1978), an interaction between two individuals involves each participant taking on the role of the other, and adjusting their behaviour to the responses of one another. Thus, an individual needs to both process incoming information, as well as developing a strategy of how to present themselves in a meaningful way. From Plato to Shakespeare, it has often been remarked that human social life is analogous with that of actors on a stage. This dramaturgical analogy was theoretically applied by Erving Goffman (1955, 1959, 1963, 1974) to the study of human interactions. Through this formulation, Goffman (1955, 1959, 1963) argued that social actors were involved in a continuous management of the impressions they give to others. For Goffman (1959, 1963), the ability to manage such impressions is fundamental for an individual to be considered ‘normal’ by others. Hence, those that exhibit autism, whether diagnosed or not, are likely to be considered abnormal and subsequently stigmatised.

To Goffman (1963), a stigma is an attribute, behaviour, or social category that is socially discrediting to the individual. Goffman (1963) described stigma as the gap between the actual social identity an individual inhabits in lived reality, and the ‘virtual social identity’ expected of them by an idealised social norm. Those who occupy such a social position can be classified as either ‘discredited’ or ‘discreditable’. Those ‘discredited’ being those who have had their stigma revealed to others, or who are openly visible. The problem here in terms of impression management, is how to manage social interactions when one knows they are known to hold a stigmatising attribute which can affect interactions with

others. For the 'discreditable', the stigma is not known about, and therefore impression management involves the concealment of stigma (known as 'passing'), and when to reveal information about the attribute and to whom. Goffman (1963) suggests that the stigmatised may well see themselves as 'normal', yet at the same time will realise that they are 'different' within the presence of 'normal' people. An identity that can cause social shame, and when internalised through a 'self fulfilling prophecy'

(Becker, 1963) can lead to low self-esteem and even self-degradation. In the case of autism, amongst other perceived differences, it is the very ability to manage impressions that is viewed as abnormal and not meeting social expectation. Even those deemed 'high-functioning' and who with a great deal of conscious effort are able to 'pass as normal', can then be stigmatised as 'falsely' claiming their autistic status, and further disabled by not having their difficulties recognised.

Jones et al. (1984) expanded Goffman's ideas on stigma to six dimensions: the extent to which a stigma is concealable, whether the stigma becomes more prominent over time, the degree to which the stigma disrupts social interactions, the aesthetics of other's reactions to the stigma, the origin of the stigma (birth, accidental, or deliberate), and the danger perceived by others on how the stigma may affect them. Although all of these dimensions can affect autistic people to greater or lesser degrees, two of them are of particular interest: obviously, stigma that disrupts social interactions, yet increasingly, the stigma of perceived danger which can be linked to notions of a 'lack of empathy'.

Concluding Remarks

This paper has examined aspects of what it is to be autistic from a micro-sociological perspective, highlighting issues of social interaction and stigma. In so doing, it has shown some of the inadequacies of 'outsider' approaches that objectify the autistic subject from normative/functionalist perspectives, in particular the pernicious view of autistic people lacking 'empathy'. It is also anticipated that such reflections could lead to research utilising micro-sociological perspectives in conjunction with phenomenological and discursive methods.

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